

A still from the TV show Mad Men showing two men in suits sitting at a bar. The man on the left is looking towards the man on the right, who is holding a martini glass. The background is a dimly lit bar with other patrons and a warm, ambient light.

Red in the Face: A Study in Power and Humiliation

An analysis of *Mad Men*, Season 1, Episode 7

The Boiling Point

This episode brings the **dysfunctional relationship** between **Don Draper** and **Roger Sterling** to a head, exposing the **rivalry, resentment**, and **manipulation** beneath their partnership. "**Red in the Face**" uses the pervasive culture of alcoholism not as a social lubricant, but as a weapon. The narrative pivots on a calculated, drinking-related humiliation that redefines the power dynamic between the two men.

**Dysfunctional Relationship • Rivalry •
Resentment • Humiliation • Alcoholism**



The Anatomy of an Episode



1. The Alpha's Gambit

Don and Roger's brutal battle for professional and personal dominance.



2. The Gilded Cage

Betty Draper's performance of domestic perfection and its hidden traumas.



3. The Undercurrents

The simmering ambitions and systemic sexism defining the Sterling Cooper ecosystem.

The Alpha's Gambit

A Friendship Built on Resentment

The relationship between Don and Roger is a study in competitive codependency. Roger Sterling, the senior partner, is grappling with getting older and the fading of his authority. Don Draper is the younger, more brilliant talent who resents Roger's entitled position.

The central conflict in "Red in the Face" is triggered by professional slights that escalate into a deeply personal confrontation, turning their complex friendship into a battlefield.



The Alpha's Gambit

Power, Poured into a Glass

In the world of 1960s Madison Avenue, excessive drinking and smoking are not just habits; they are instruments of power and status. Don masterfully exploits Roger's well-established weaknesses for alcohol and gluttony, transforming a social lunch into the staging ground for his attack. The pervasive industry culture of excess becomes the very weapon of Roger's downfall.



The Alpha's Gambit

A Calculated Takedown

The episode's central event is the meticulously orchestrated humiliation of Roger Sterling by Don Draper. This is not a friendly rivalry that goes too far; it is a cold, precise act designed to publicly assert dominance.

By pushing Roger past his physical limits in a setting rife with alcohol, Don doesn't just win a petty competition—he seizes control of their professional dynamic.



The Gilded Cage

The Performance of Perfection

Betty Draper's storyline explores the crushing weight of being the "1960s ideal housewife." Her life is a carefully curated illusion, defined by her fashionable suburban style of pastel dresses and pearl accessories. This episode continues to expose the deep cracks in that facade, highlighting the profound trauma and loneliness simmering just beneath her perfect exterior.

"Her marriage to Don is an illusion."



The Gilded Cage

The Guest in Her Home

The two central narratives collide when Roger's alcohol-fueled behavior spills over into the Draper home. His unwanted advances toward Betty are more than a plot point; they are a violation of her sanctuary. This moment underscores Betty's powerlessness and deepens her domestic trauma, proving that the fallout from the men's competitive world inevitably contaminates her own.



The Undercurrents

The View from the Bottom

While Don and Roger engage in their high-stakes power plays, Peggy Olson is quietly playing a different game.

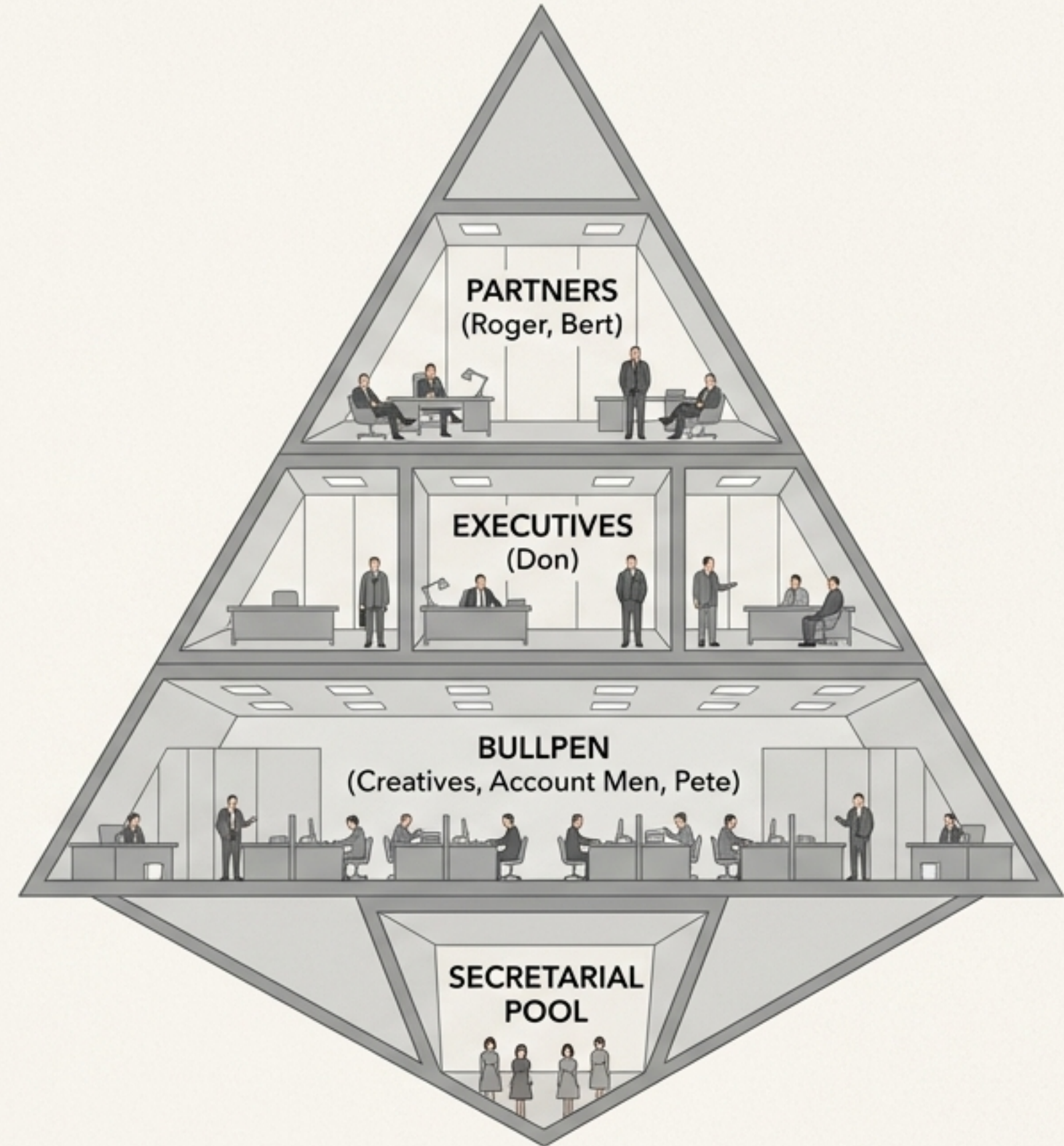
This episode continues to track her evolution from a low-status secretary, visually marked by her “humble and conservative outfits,” to an aspiring professional. She observes the male-dominated environment, learning from its flaws to fuel her own “creative and business aspirations” over the traditional path of marriage.



The Undercurrents

A Man's World

The Sterling Cooper office depicted in this episode is a systemically "male-dominated" environment where "sexism is rampant." The culture is the backdrop for all the character conflicts. Ambitious figures like Pete Campbell represent another form of ascent within this broken system, constantly maneuvering for status and recognition in a world defined by male power structures.



Three Faces of Power

"Red in the Face" presents a triptych of power dynamics in 1960 America:



DON: Wields power through cold manipulation and the exploitation of weakness.



BETTY: A victim of systemic powerlessness, trapped within the illusion of domesticity.



PEGGY: Seeks power by subverting the system from within, through observation and ambition.

What's in a Name: "Red in the Face"

"Red in the Face"

The Thematic

The heated passion, danger, and resentment simmering just just beneath the surface of their polished lives.

The Literal

Roger Sterling's flushed face from alcohol and the exertion of climbing stairs.

Red in the Face

The Subconscious

Don's own suppressed anger (rage) that fuels his actions.

The Metaphorical

The deep embarrassment and public humiliation he suffers.

The Aftershocks

This episode is a point of no return. It permanently damages the foundation of the Don and Roger relationship, setting the stage for future conflict and foreshadowing Roger's later health crises related to his lifestyle.

Critically, it also adds another significant crack to the "illusion" of the Drapers' marriage, accelerating the decay of their domestic life.



An Irononic Coda

The episode concludes with the end-credits music: **"Botch-A-Me (Ba-Ba-Baciami Piccina)" by Rosemary Clooney**. The song's jaunty, playful, and slightly nonsensical Italian-American novelty stands in jarring contrast to the dark, tense, and psychologically brutal events that have just transpired. This is a classic *Mad Men* technique: masking deep emotional turmoil with a veneer of cheerful, disposable pop culture.





Beneath the polished surface, a brutal reckoning.